

Slide 7: Debate and Public Opinion

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The impact of WikiLeaks has sparked intense debate and divided public opinion across the globe:

Public Perception of Harm vs. Benefit

A 2010 Pew Research survey found that 60% of Americans believed the WikiLeaks release of diplomatic cables harmed the public interest, while 31% thought it served the public interest^[1]. However, opinions varied along partisan lines, with 75% of Republicans viewing it as harmful compared to 53% of Democrats^[1:1].

Support for Leaks

A 2022 Morning Consult survey revealed that adults across Europe, Australia, and the United States were more likely to say Assange was "right" than "wrong" to release classified U.S. material^[2]. However, in most cases, the largest share of respondents had no opinion on specific leaks^[2:1].

Views on Prosecution

In 2013, 54% of Americans, including equal majorities of Republicans and Democrats (59% each), supported pursuing criminal charges against those responsible for leaking classified NSA information^[3]. However, younger people (under 30) were more divided on this issue^[3:1].

Global Perspective

A 2011 global poll by Ipsos found that 79% of people were aware of WikiLeaks, and among those, two-thirds believed Assange should not be charged^[4].

Impact on Government Trust

WikiLeaks has potentially contributed to declining trust in the U.S. federal government. Since 2007, fewer than 3 in 10 Americans have expressed trust in the federal government in major national polls^[5].

Debate Among Civil Rights Organizations

While many civil rights groups acknowledge WikiLeaks' role in exposing human rights violations, some criticize its tactics and worry about potential negative consequences, such as increased government secrecy and restrictions on information access^[6].

The ongoing debate surrounding WikiLeaks highlights the complex balance between transparency, national security, and the public's right to information.

1. <https://www.pewresearch.org/politics/2010/12/08/most-say-wikileaks-release-harms-public-interest/>
2. <https://pro.morningconsult.com/instant-intel/many-in-the-west-support-assanges-leaks>
3. <https://www.pewresearch.org/politics/2013/06/17/public-split-over-impact-of-nsa-leak-but-most-want-snowden-prosecuted/>
4. <https://www.reuters.com/article/world/wikileaks-julian-assange-is-not-a-criminal-global-poll-idUSTRE73P78C/>
5. https://digitalcommons.pace.edu/cgi/viewcontent.cgi?article=1272&context=honorscollege_theses
6. <https://www.ifla.org/publications/what-is-the-effect-of-wikileaks-for-freedom-of-information/>